Akshay Chalana

(425) 892-5977 · akshay@chalana.com · linkedin.com/in/akshaychalana · github.com/Ac2zoom

TECHNICAL FOUNDER · AI SYSTEMS · ENGINEERING LEADERSHIP

EXPERIENCE

Saphira AI (YC S24) | Co-Founder & CEO
2024 – Present
San Francisco, CA

- Built and led the product and engineering organization for an AI-native platform that helps teams reason about complex physical systems across robotics, autonomy, automotive, aerospace, and industrial products.
- Set technical direction for agentic workflows spanning system context, failure analysis, requirements, validation, simulation outputs, and evidence traceability; remained hands-on in architecture, model and tool selection, and customer deployments.
- Deployed production AI systems with customers including Airbus, Volvo, 1X, Zoox, and May Mobility, translating expert engineering workflows into agent tools and evaluation loops.
- Recruited and developed a cross-functional team while owning company strategy, enterprise sales, and the engineering roadmap.

Citadel Securities | Systems Software Engineer, Trading Ecosystem
2021 – 2024
New York, NY

- Led product and systems roadmaps for high-reliability front-office workflows, mentored engineers, and coordinated delivery across trading, operations, compliance, and engineering stakeholders.
- Owned Python and C++ trading systems across the full software lifecycle, consolidating dozens of legacy applications and enabling roughly 1,000× growth in daily trade throughput.

Apple | Software Engineer, ML Platform
2019 – 2021
Seattle, WA

- Built distributed systems in Go, Java, and Python for high-performance movement and processing of ML experiment data, supporting large-scale model development workflows.
- Designed low-latency analytics infrastructure for ML experimentation and research, improving engineers' ability to inspect and understand model-development data.

Meta | Software Engineering Intern, PyTorch / ONNX
2018
Menlo Park, CA

- Designed and implemented the ONNX opset version converter, enabling backward compatibility across evolving model operators and production ML workflows.

Tesla | Software Engineering Intern, Reliability / Test Automation
2016
Palo Alto, CA

- Built Python test interfaces, embedded C++ firmware, and test-data visualization for hardware reliability testing across engineering teams.

EDUCATION

University of Washington | B.S., Computer Science (Data Science) and Mathematics
2015 – 2019

TECHNICAL SKILLS

AI systems: LLM agents, evaluation, tool use, retrieval and context systems, multimodal pipelines, PyTorch
Systems: Python, C++, Go, Java, distributed systems, cloud infrastructure, Docker
Leadership: engineering management, hiring and team development, technical strategy, enterprise deployment